DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

The Book So Far: Sections One to Eight

Daat Tevunot, Summary

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** Summary of §1-160 (sections 1-8 of the book) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 12 October 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Why review now

After the Sukkot break, and in the week after the attacks of 7 October, the Rabbi opened by saying that section 9, coming next, is "almost the crescendo" of the book and especially timely. People are still too raw to ask the question fully, but they are asking: where is HaKadosh Barukh Hu in all of this? "I don't profess to give you the full answer," he said, and nor does the Ramhal. What the Ramhal gives is guiding principles. Section 10 will then be a new topic: the cycle of time and the seasons.

Before going on, he reviewed the first eight sections from the English summary on page 653, since "it's important always that we have the structure of the book."

1. The purpose

The purpose of life is to emulate HaKadosh Barukh Hu as much as we can, to become good people and so cleave to Him in the world to come, which is the greatest pleasure. And we must earn it ourselves.

2. The means: God's unity

The central factor on which all existence revolves is the revelation of the Yihud Hashem. God's oneness means not only that there is one God, but that there is no other power: nothing can oppose His will. The purpose of creation is to bestow good; the means God chose is to make all existence depend on the revelation of His unity.

That revelation requires two phases. First evil exists; then it is destroyed, showing it never had power of its own. The second phase, the Rabbi stressed, is not Mashiah but olam haba, at the end of the six thousand years, in this world rectified. Adam could have brought this about himself; because he sinned, the six thousand years are for repairing what he damaged. He noted that the Torah calls him "ha-adam", the man: Adam is humanity.

3. Concealment

During the phase of earning reward, God conceals His presence so that we can choose. Even then He is the source of everything; otherwise the world would cease to exist. By concealing Himself He set up a system of forces that reacts to our good and bad deeds, bringing light or darkness, which is what sections 7 and 8 elaborated. But the emanation of perfection works in the background, guiding everything to perfection whether man deserves it or not. That is section 9.

4. Body and soul

Man is a combination of a coarse body and an elevated soul in constant struggle. The soul comes from the revelation of God's presence, the body from concealment. When the soul prevails, a person is filled with light; when the body prevails, with darkness. The body has many parts, like concealment which is division, while the soul is one, like the Yihud. The Rabbi admitted he still has no full answer to the question asked at the time: in Derech Hashem the Ramhal says the soul has five parts. But it is certainly more unified than the body.

The balance shifts over time. During the six thousand years concealment dominates. In the seventh millennium revelation dominates, though some concealment remains, like Moshe on the mountain, not eating or drinking but still physical. At the end the body no longer has any noticeable influence.

5. Evil

Evil is something new that God created to test man, and it is temporary. God does not create evil by a direct emanation, since He is wholly good. He sends an emanation that would give good and then holds it back; the arrangement becomes damaged, and that is evil. Unfortunately, said the Rabbi, the amount of evil in the world is "shocking", but that is what happens when Hashem holds back.

All of creation is one interconnected system, like cogs in a machine, dependent on man's actions. Evil within the system becomes a vehicle for good: from darkness we recognise light, overcoming tests brings reward, and we are given the task of perfecting the world. This, he said, is why people now talk of putting on tefillin or doing a misvah to help the soldiers in Israel. "What's the connection? Because it's one big interconnected system."

6. Adam before and after the sin

In Gan Eden Adam could already sin, so he was not perfect, but he was immeasurably higher than we are. His body was at the level of our soul today, and his world was more refined. Because he fell, our tikkun is a "double" task: first to return to his level before the sin, then to go higher.

Destruction comes from lack of unity, which is why we speak so much about ahdut: unity between people below allows unity above. And nothing is ever totally destroyed. A trace always remains from which it can be rebuilt, even after death, and so too the Jewish people through the bitterness of exile. "With the events of the past week, how can we say that? I don't know, but there must be some good in it. We have to be careful how we speak."

7. How God acts on the world

The apparent and principal system is cause and effect: good deeds bring light, bad deeds the opposite. In this phase the world depends on God's judgment, and judgment is good. Without it the wicked dominate and the righteous are oppressed. When the world has no merit at all, God hides and does not judge, and the world plunges into darkness. So there are really three modes: din, rahamim, and a third, worst mode of no response at all. Judgment comes from love, like a father who chastises his child, and it can be softened.

The group reviewed the five levels of revelation; the English summary lists them in chronological order rather than the order in the book.

8. The force that sustains creation

Man has a dual nature: the most elevated of creatures when he perfects himself, and the most prone to evil. God wants His oneness revealed through man turning evil into good. "Just imagine what would happen if we took all this evil now and used it as a springboard to create more love." Man is unique in having free choice, and when the righteous use it, they come face to face with God, like the Keruvim.

Next time: section 9, and an attempt to make some sense of what has been happening.

Summary

- Purpose: to become good and cleave to God, earned through our own choices. Means: the revelation of God's unity, which needs a phase of evil and a phase of its destruction.
- Concealment allows choice and creates a system of reward and punishment, while a hidden emanation guides everything to perfection.
- Body and soul mirror concealment and revelation, and their balance shifts over the millennia.
- Evil is a holding back of God's emanation; built into one interconnected system, it becomes a vehicle for good, and nothing is ever wholly destroyed.
- Judgment is good; the worst state is no response at all. Section 9 will address the hidden guidance behind events.

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